

The Cold War

After World War II, the USA and the Soviet Union (USSR) emerged as the world's most powerful countries. Although bitter enemies, the threat of nuclear destruction stopped them from declaring war. Instead, they each tried to weaken the other by spying, supporting other countries in conflicts, and developing new technologies.

THE WORLD DIVIDED

As tensions grew between the two superpowers, they each tried to form alliances with other countries. By the mid-1950s, all of Europe and most of the world had chosen sides in the Cold War.

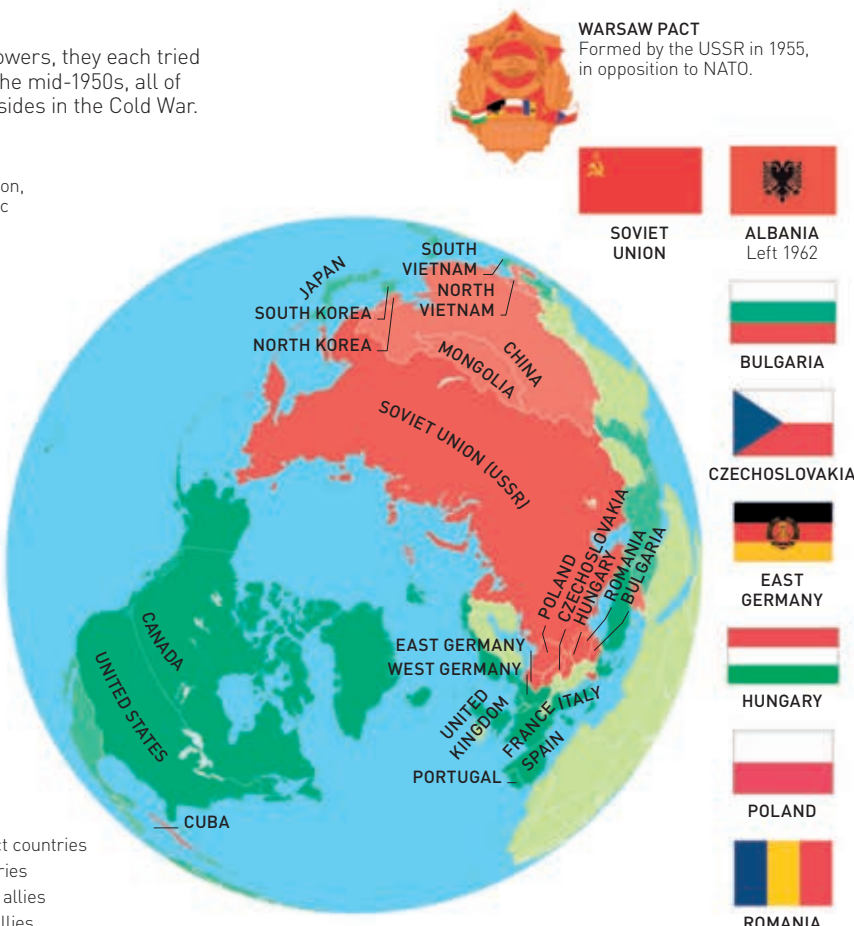


NATO
The North Atlantic Treaty Organization, an alliance of 12 Western democratic countries, formed in 1949.



EUROPE 1955

■ Warsaw Pact countries
■ NATO countries
■ Other USSR allies
■ Other USA allies

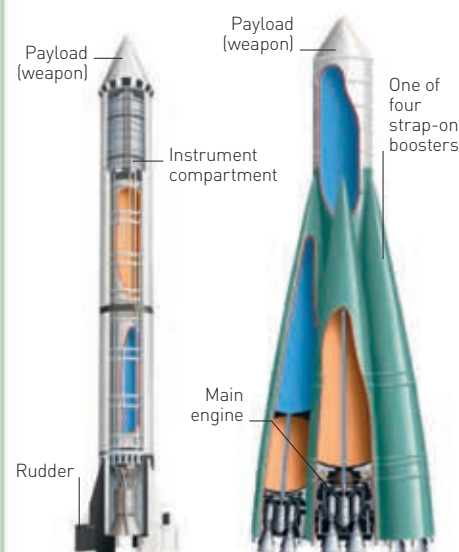
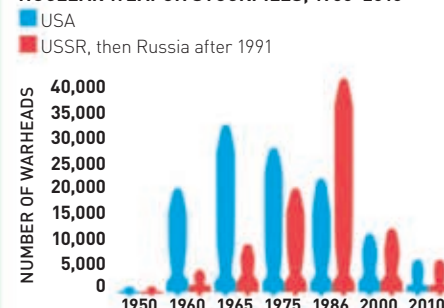


WARSAW PACT
Formed by the USSR in 1955, in opposition to NATO.

NUCLEAR ARMS

After World War II, only the United States had nuclear bomb technology, but in 1949 the USSR successfully tested a nuclear device of its own. The nuclear arms race began, with both countries building more and more powerful weapons and stockpiling thousands of warheads.

NUCLEAR WEAPON STOCKPILES, 1950-2010



PGM-11 REDSTONE (USA)
First missile to carry a live nuclear warhead.

R-7 SEMYORKA (USSR)
First intercontinental ballistic missile.

NATO LEADERS

In 1949 the USA brought together a group of countries to form a military union. NATO's aims were to stop the spread of Communism and help prevent future war in Europe. As the USA was the most powerful country in NATO, the US president was seen as its leader.



DWIGHT D. EISENHOWER
Became US president in 1953. He promised help to countries who were under threat from the spread of Communism.



JOHN F. KENNEDY
When Kennedy confronted the USSR in 1962 over weapons they held in Cuba, many feared that it would trigger a third world war.



RICHARD NIXON
Nixon started a slight thaw in the Cold War when he met the Soviet leader Leonid Brezhnev in 1972, to discuss reducing weapons.



RONALD REAGAN
The US president in charge at the end of the Cold War, Reagan signed a peace treaty in 1989 with Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev.

WARSAW PACT LEADERS

The Pact was an anti-NATO alliance between Communist nations. Communism was based on the belief that property should not be owned by individuals, but shared by everyone.



JOSEPH STALIN
Set the Cold War in motion by bringing much of Eastern Europe under Soviet control after World War II.



NIKITA KHRUSHCHEV
Tried to establish better relations with the USA, but was ousted as Soviet leader by rivals in 1964.



FIDEL CASTRO
Led a Communist revolution in Cuba in 1959. The USA supported many attempts to remove him from power.



MIKHAIL GORBACHEV
Became leader of the USSR in 1985, and introduced many reforms that helped bring an end to the Cold War.

THE BERLIN WALL

After World War II, Germany's capital was divided up between the Allied countries – UK, USA, France, and USSR. In 1961 the Soviets built a 2 m (6.5 ft) high wall enclosing the three sectors of West Berlin to stop people escaping from the Communist Soviet sector to the Allied sector. The heavily guarded wall was finally demolished in 1989, at the end of the Cold War.

